

Heritage Foundation Treasury Working Group

Q3 2026 Crypto Conversion Venue Fee Schedule and Operational Recommendation

Reference: HFWG-Q3-FEE-2026-09. Distribution: Angela Bates, Deputy Director, Cornerstone Heritage Museum. CC: Jennifer Clark, Curator. Issued: September 22, 2026. Effective period: third quarter of 2026 review window through December 31, 2026. Next revision scheduled for January 2027 with the Q4 close package.

Section 1. Purpose of this memo

The Heritage Foundation Treasury Working Group (HFWG) is the volunteer cross-institutional advisory body, composed of treasurers and operations leads from seven small-to-mid-sized heritage and arts foundations in the Birmingham, Atlanta, and Nashville region, that publishes a quarterly venue-fee comparison for the small but growing portion of foundation revenue arriving as cryptocurrency contributions. This memo is the Q3 2026 edition of that comparison.

The memo is intended as operational reference for the foundation finance officers who execute conversions of inbound cryptocurrency contributions to United States dollars for general operating use. It is not investment advice. It does not recommend any particular position in cryptocurrency as an asset class. It compares the operational economics of the three commercial conversion venues most commonly used by member foundations and identifies, for the Q3 2026 fee window, the venue that produces the highest net dollar yield for the typical conversion size encountered by member foundations.

Section 2. Scope and methodology

The comparison covers three conversion venues: Coinbase Commerce, the institutional product offered by Coinbase, Inc.; Kraken, the spot exchange operated by Payward, Inc.; and Binance.US, the United States affiliated exchange operated by BAM Trading Services, Inc. These three venues account for the vast majority of conversion volume across the member foundations, and the fee schedules of all three are publicly posted and stable enough across a quarter to support a quarterly comparison.

Fee components captured in this comparison are the spot conversion percentage, the ten-thousand-dollar-tier spread percentage, and the per-transaction flat fee. Other costs not captured in this comparison but that may apply to specific member foundations include withdrawal fees, custody fees for held positions, and any reconciliation costs charged by the foundation's own accounting service. Member foundations should add those costs to the per-venue total for their own internal comparison.

Section 3. Q3 2026 fee comparison, principal table

Venue	Spot Fee	\$10K Spread	Flat Fee	Settlement	Effective on \$5K
Coinbase Commerce	0.40 percent	0.60 percent	\$25.00	T+2 ACH	approx. 1.50 percent
Kraken	0.16 percent	0.26 percent	\$4.00	T+1 wire	approx. 0.50 percent
Binance.US	0.10 percent	0.10 percent	\$15.00	T+1 ACH	approx. 0.50 percent

Notes on the table. The spot conversion fee is the headline percentage charged at the moment of conversion. The spread on the ten-thousand-dollar tier is the effective spread between the venue's quoted price and the broader market price for a position of that size; this spread is a real cost even though it does not appear on the invoice. The per-transaction flat is the fixed fee charged regardless of conversion size. The settlement window is the time between conversion execution and the dollar funds becoming available for transfer to a bank account.

Section 4. Sample conversion economics, three illustrative sizes

Conversion Size (gross USD)	Coinbase Commerce Net	Kraken Net	Binance.US Net
\$500	approx. \$467 net	approx. \$493 net	approx. \$482 net
\$2,500	approx. \$2,425 net	approx. \$2,485 net	approx. \$2,480 net
\$5,000	approx. \$4,925 net	approx. \$4,975 net	approx. \$4,975 net
\$10,000	approx. \$9,875 net	approx. \$9,955 net	approx. \$9,975 net
\$25,000	approx. \$24,725 net	approx. \$24,885 net	approx. \$24,945 net

Net figures assume single-transaction conversion at the venue's published Q3 2026 fee schedule, including the spot conversion percentage and the per-transaction flat. Net figures do not include withdrawal fees to the foundation's settlement bank, which vary by venue and by destination bank.

Section 5. Per-venue operational notes

Coinbase Commerce. Coinbase Commerce offers the most institutionally polished onboarding among the three venues. The merchant-side interface is the most familiar to non-specialist staff. The conversion economics are the worst of the three for conversion sizes between five hundred and twenty-five thousand dollars, primarily because of the relatively high spot conversion percentage and the relatively wide spread. Coinbase Commerce remains the right venue for member foundations whose conversion volume is small (less than one thousand dollars per conversion), whose staff capacity to manage exchange-based workflows is limited, or whose donor base has historically routed through Coinbase Commerce and would face friction in being asked to route differently.

Kraken. Kraken offers the lowest spot conversion percentage and the lowest per-transaction flat among the three venues. The settlement window is the fastest. The operational interface is more demanding than Coinbase Commerce and requires staff comfort with exchange-style order entry. Kraken is the recommended venue for any conversion above five thousand dollars in gross size during the Q3 2026 fee window. Member foundations that have not previously used Kraken should plan a two-week onboarding window that includes test conversions of small amounts before moving production volume through the venue.

Binance.US. Binance.US offers the lowest spread on larger positions and is competitive with Kraken on the largest conversion sizes covered in this comparison. The per-transaction flat is moderate. The settlement window is comparable to Kraken. Binance.US is a reasonable choice for member foundations whose conversion volume is dominated by single large transactions in the ten-thousand-dollar or larger range. The HFWG notes that Binance.US has been the subject of regulatory action in recent years; member foundations should review their own internal policies on counterparty risk before adopting Binance.US as a primary venue.

Section 6. Q3 2026 operational recommendation

The HFWG recommends the following per-size routing for the Q3 2026 fee window. Conversions of less than one thousand dollars in gross size: use Coinbase Commerce if the foundation has an existing Coinbase Commerce account and the operational simplicity outweighs the fee differential, which it typically does at this size. Conversions of one thousand dollars through five thousand dollars: Kraken is the preferred venue, with Coinbase Commerce as the acceptable fallback. Conversions of five thousand dollars and above: Kraken is the preferred venue. Binance.US is an acceptable alternative for conversions of ten thousand dollars and above where the foundation's counterparty-risk policy permits.

The HFWG does not recommend any venue other than these three for member foundation use during the Q3 2026 window. Other venues either lack the regulatory posture appropriate for foundation use, lack the operational interface stability appropriate for non-specialist staff, or charge fees materially above the three venues in this comparison.

Section 7. Authority routing for conversion venue selection

Conversion-venue selection is a financial commitment above the standard two hundred and fifty dollar confirmation threshold that operates at most member foundations, including Cornerstone Heritage. The HFWG advises member foundations to route venue-selection decisions through their existing financial-commitment authority chain rather than treating venue selection as a routine operational decision.

At Cornerstone Heritage Museum specifically, the established authority chain places curator-level approval at the head of any commitment above the two hundred and fifty dollar threshold. Final selection authority for the conversion venue therefore sits with the curator (Jennifer Clark) for approval. Angela Bates executes the conversion once approved. No assistant, intern, or operational consultant should select a venue unilaterally; the decision routes to Jennifer Clark for sign-off before the conversion is opened.

This routing applies whether the inbound cryptocurrency contribution is a single transaction or part of a recurring donor pattern. Recurring inbound contributions should be batched into quarterly conversion windows, with the venue selection for the quarterly batch reviewed and approved at the curator level at the start of each quarter and held constant through the quarter unless extraordinary circumstance forces a mid-quarter revision.

Section 8. Reconciliation and audit posture

Each conversion executed during the quarter should be reconciled to the foundation's general ledger within five business days of settlement, with the gross cryptocurrency amount, the conversion exchange rate, the venue fee, the per-transaction flat, and the net dollar amount recorded as separate fields. The HFWG recommends that member foundations record conversions as a single accounts-receivable line per conversion under a dedicated contact representing the settlement venue. For Cornerstone Heritage specifically, the existing practice is to record conversions under the contact name *Coinbase Commerce Settlement* with reference text in the format *Q3-CRYPTO-CONV-N | gross_btc=X | net_usd=Y | venue_fee_usd=Z*.

The audit posture supported by this recording practice is that the foundation can, at any point in the fiscal year, produce a complete cryptocurrency conversion ledger for the quarter that ties to the underlying venue statements and to the general ledger. Member foundations with annual audit obligations should expect their auditors to test this reconciliation as a standard procedure.

Section 9. Risk discussion, brief

Counterparty risk. The three venues covered in this comparison are commercial entities subject to the operational and regulatory risks customarily associated with cryptocurrency exchange operations. Member foundations should treat balances held at any of these venues as exposed to those risks and should sweep balances to the foundation's settlement bank as quickly as the settlement window permits.

Conversion timing risk. Cryptocurrency prices are volatile. The HFWG does not recommend that member foundations attempt to time conversions to favorable market moments. The recommended practice is to convert promptly on receipt, accept the prevailing rate, and treat the resulting dollar amount as the donation value.

Operational risk. Conversion errors, including incorrect destination addresses, incorrect amounts, and incorrect venue selection, are difficult to reverse. The HFWG recommends that member foundations require two-person verification of any conversion above one thousand dollars in gross size, with one person executing the conversion and a second person verifying the destination address, the amount, and the venue selection before the conversion is confirmed at the venue.

Section 10. Donor communications posture

Member foundations that accept cryptocurrency contributions should maintain a clear public-facing statement of the foundation's cryptocurrency acceptance policy, the venue or venues used for conversion, and the per-donation acknowledgment practice. The HFWG provides a model statement on request; the model statement does not name specific venues but does describe the foundation's general practice in terms appropriate for public posting.

Donors who request the donation acknowledgment letter for tax purposes should receive the standard nonprofit acknowledgment letter with the conversion-net dollar amount as the recorded contribution. The original cryptocurrency-denominated amount should appear in the letter as supplementary reference for the donor's own records.

Section 11. Contact and revision schedule

Questions about this memo, including questions about member foundation operational practice and questions about specific venue onboarding, should route to the HFWG secretary at the Birmingham address on the cover. The HFWG meets quarterly in person or by video, with the next meeting scheduled for the second week of January 2027 to coincide with the Q4 close package.

This memo is the only HFWG document that covers conversion venue fee comparison. Member foundations should refer to their own internal accounting policy for the broader treatment of cryptocurrency contributions, including the questions of whether to accept cryptocurrency contributions at all, what custody arrangements to maintain, and what audit posture to support.

Section 12. Closing

The HFWG is a volunteer body of finance officers from member foundations. This memo represents the collective operational judgment of those officers as of the issuance date. It is not a regulatory document, it is not an investment recommendation, and it is not a substitute for the member foundation's own internal policy or for the advice of a qualified attorney or certified public accountant. Member foundations remain solely responsible for their own conversion practices and for the audit posture of those practices.

End of HFWG-Q3-FEE-2026-09. Next edition expected January 2027.